

Damara Cohn

DELRAY BEACH · LOCAL AUTHORITY GUIDE

The Real Delray Beach Guide

The civic structure, real history, and annual rhythm of Delray Beach — the parts of this city a listing page never shows you, from someone who's sold this stretch of coast for 25+ years.

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A NOTE FROM DAMARA



Delray Beach is more than Atlantic Avenue —

I've sold real estate in Delray Beach for more than 25 years, and I still meet people moving here who've never heard of the Downtown Development Authority, don't know the Community Redevelopment Agency exists, or have no idea the city runs on a real annual calendar beyond "season." None of that shows up on a listing page.

This guide is the version of Delray Beach I'd walk you through in person — how downtown is actually organized, a landmark worth knowing beyond Old School Square, and the events that fill the calendar every year. It's not a top-ten list; it's the kind of context that makes a place feel like home instead of just an address.

A few of the details here — district boundaries, agency structures, event dates — come from the city's own Downtown Development Authority, its Community Redevelopment Agency, and the Greater Delray Beach Chamber of Commerce, current as of 2026. Dates and hours can shift year to year, so treat this as a real starting point, not a locked calendar.

One more thing, since it matters to how I work: I run a boutique brokerage, not a large national franchise. That means the person you talk to on day one is the same person overseeing your transaction on day sixty — my personal attention, my 25+ years of local expertise. If anything in here raises a question, just ask me directly.

Damara

BROKER-OWNER, MANGROVE REALTY

Six Districts, One Downtown

Downtown Delray Beach isn't run informally — it's governed by its own Downtown Development Authority (DDA), a special taxing district created in 1971 when downtown property owners asked the state for a stronger, unified voice at City Hall. The DDA divides downtown into six official districts, each with its own focus:

The Ave

Atlantic Avenue itself — downtown's central spine of restaurants, galleries, and retail.

SOFA (South of Atlantic)

The fast-growing area just south of Atlantic Avenue, home to well over a million square feet of comparatively recent mixed-use construction.

West Atlantic

The western end of the corridor, currently a focus of city and CRA investment in streetscape, housing, and new business development.

Pineapple Grove

The arts district north of Atlantic Avenue, anchored by galleries and studio space.

US1

The Federal Highway corridor through downtown — Delray's commercial gateway from the north and south.

Beachside

The barrier island area east of the Intracoastal, home to the public beach and AIA's oceanfront stretch.

Downtown's transformation over the past few decades also runs through a second public body: the **Delray Beach Community Redevelopment Agency (CRA)**, created in 1985 by the City Commission to address deteriorated conditions and guide long-term revitalization. It covers roughly 20% of the city — the Central Business District and surrounding neighborhoods — funded through tax-increment financing, meaning it reinvests the added property-tax value its own improvements generate. A seven-member board (five city commissioners plus two appointees) oversees infrastructure, housing, and beautification projects. Two separate public agencies actively shaping downtown is a real reason some blocks have changed faster than others — it isn't accidental, it's planned.

WORTH KNOWING

A Landmark, and a Real Calendar

The Spady Cultural Heritage Museum

Just off Atlantic Avenue in the West Settlers District sits the Spady Cultural Heritage Museum, housed in the former home of Solomon D. Spady, an educator who studied under George Washington Carver and led Delray's segregation-era Black public school as principal from 1922 to 1957. The museum opened in 2001 and today preserves the history of Delray Beach's African-American community — a genuine landmark that gives downtown far more depth than its restaurants and storefronts alone.

The Delray Beach Calendar

February

The Delray Beach Open

An ATP 250 professional tennis tournament, played on the hard courts of the Delray Beach Stadium & Tennis Center.

April

The Delray Affair

One of the largest arts-and-crafts festivals in the Southeast, spanning seven blocks of Atlantic Avenue, run by the Greater Delray Beach Chamber of Commerce.

Oct – May, Saturdays

The Delray Beach GreenMarket

A Saturday-morning farmers' market at the Old School Square campus, 9am to 2pm.

Most years

South Florida Garlic Fest

A full weekend food festival that draws crowds from across the county.

BEFORE YOU MOVE

A Few Practical Things Worth Knowing

The small, practical details that make the first few visits easier.

1

Downtown parking is metered and garage-based

Atlantic Avenue itself is largely metered curbside parking, with public garages within walking distance — worth knowing before your first visit, not after circling the block.

2

Beach parking is public and metered

Delray's public beach runs the length of A1A with metered public parking open to residents and visitors alike — no permit required, unlike some neighboring towns.

3

The GreenMarket is the weekly gathering point

Saturday mornings, October through May, at Old School Square — a good first stop for getting a feel for the community before you've moved a single box.

4

The calendar shifts with the season

Downtown gets noticeably busier during the Delray Affair (April) and the Delray Beach Open (February) — worth factoring into any visit you're planning to see the city for yourself.

IN THEIR WORDS

"Damara made my stressful and challenging transaction a BREEZE. I highly recommend her for knowledge, experience and professionalism. In other words, you will enjoy working with her."

— BERNARD, GOOGLE REVIEW

LET'S TALK

Honest answers. Genuine care. 25+ years of experience.

I run a boutique brokerage, not a large national franchise — which means you get my direct oversight, attention, and expertise, not a hand-off to someone you've never spoken to.

Whether you're relocating from out of state or moving three blocks over, I'm happy to walk you through Delray Beach in person — call or text anytime.

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Mangrove Realty, Inc. · Licensed Real Estate Brokerage

Damara Cohn, Broker-Owner, Mangrove Realty · Delray Beach, FL · This guide is for general informational purposes only. District boundaries, agency information, and event dates reflect publicly available information as of 2026 and are subject to change — confirm current details with the City of Delray Beach, the DDA, the CRA, or event organizers directly. Not tax or legal advice.